appreciate that in mainstreaming Jammu & Kashmir, we have not just strengthened national integrity but also enhanced national security. And this is absolutely vital as India raises its profile on the global stage. Certainly, our Western partners today are much more understanding. But let that not cloud the fact that the real change has been in our own position that draws inspiration from Dr S.P. Mookerjee.

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A question closely related to the mishandling of the Jammu & Kashmir issue is that of India's misreading of Pakistan, its intent and its policies. This, too, is a long-standing issue that has cast its shadow for many decades on our well-being and security. And here, too, there has been a decisive shift in Indian thinking.

In Mookerjee's case, the matter acquired particular salience because it was the cause for his resignation from the Union Cabinet. He shared his assessment candidly with Parliament in 1950, diagnosing the prevalent attitude to Pakistan in words that still resonate with all of us. In essence, Mookerjee viewed Nehru's approach as weak, halting and inconsistent. In his reading, India's inaction or goodness has been interpreted by Pakistan as weakness. In fact, according to him, it has made the latter more and more intransigent, made India suffer all that much more and even lowered it in the estimation of its own people. On every important occasion, Mookerjee asserted that India has remained defensive and failed to expose or counteract the designs of Pakistan aimed at it. This could well be the natural thoughts of the average Indian citizen in the aftermath of the 26/11 attacks in Mumbai!

When it came to displaying strategic clarity about Pakistan, there is no question that Patel and Mookerjee stand out. Apart from the accession of Jammu & Kashmir and treatment of minorities, this was most notably on display where Mookerjee was concerned in regard to his own province of Bengal. Once the concept of partitioning India was accepted by the Congress, the key question became the future of Bengal, Punjab and Assam. Each of them had to be individually partitioned if the entire state was not to go to Pakistan on the basis of a tenuous majority. It was to this cause that Mookerjee then devoted his energies, ensuring that the metropolis of Calcutta (now Kolkata) and as much of Bengal as possible stayed with